# Introduction and Acknowledgements

My interest in the border conflict in the Himalayas goes back to 1967 when, as a 14-year-old schoolboy in Sweden, I sent a handwritten letter to the Indian embassy in Stockholm asking them for information about the problem. I was very young but already interested in international affairs. I was curious to know about the dispute and why it had led to a short but vicious war in 1962.

I received a box in the mail with a stack of White Papers that contained reproductions of letters, official statements from New Delhi as well as Beijing, and detailed foldout maps of areas claimed by both India and China. I became somewhat familiar with the geography of the region and learned about the basics of the conflict from the Indian point of view: China had launched a massive attack over the Himalayas; India was the victim of Chinese aggression.

The war ended with a devastating defeat for the Indians. But, to the surprise of many, the Chinese did not keep any territory they had captured in the east. After driving the Indian Army out of most of the disputed areas, the Chinese withdrew to the old Line of Actual Control (LAC) along the crest of the Himalayas. Indian administrators and military personnel could move back into those territories, which official Chinese maps even today show as part of the People's Republic of China. It was only in Ladakh in the west that the LAC was altered somewhat in China's favour.

Several years later, in the mid-1970s, I came across a book called *India's China War*. It was written by Neville Maxwell, an Anglo-Australian journalist, who presented a completely different view of the conflict. Maxwell argued that though it may have been China that attacked on 20 October 1962, it was India that had provoked the war. As part of a Forward Policy launched by independent India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal